



Our glossary expands upon significant ideas and recurring motifs found in mystic poems.
This is our attempt to open up these often dense symbols into the layers of meaning they might hold.

25 Words

All A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z

Agam Nigam (अगम नगिम, agām nigām)

Literally, the pathless path or difficult way. 'Agam' means the place to which there is no path, or difficult to get to. It also that which lies beyond the intellect. 'Nigam' means path or way. It also means the 'vedas' (therefore, a holy scripture which lies beyond the intellect). With this paradox, similar to 'unstruck sound', the poet signals a real destination but one which lies beyond our usual understanding of the world.

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Alakh (अलख, ālakh)

That which is invisible or unmanifest. It suggests the idea of that which lies beyond the senses, or that to which there is no path. Traditionally, it has been used as a description of God or the divine, but it is used with a different connotation in the nirgun strand of mystic poetry.

Amrit (अमृत, āmrit)

The nectar of heaven has been a familiar metaphor in many traditions across the ages. The etymology of the English word descends from the Greek, nek-tar (death-overcoming). In Hindi it has the same root. In mystic poetry, amrit is also referred to as 'ras', that is, sap, fluid, or juice, or the taste or essence of something; and sometimes simply as paani, water, or even boond, drops.

Heli (हेली, heli)

A short form of saheli – female friend or companion. Songs addressed to the heli belong to a whole genre of Kabir songs in Rajasthan, and may have reached Malwa from there. The address is intimate and personal, because this friend dwells in your own heart and consciousness. So in a sense, the poem is a conversation with yourself.

Sahaj (सहज, sahāj)

Spontaneous, simple or natural. Saha = together with; ja = being born or arising; ie, arising together.



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